

The SWAP Beginner Plan for 50k to 50 Miles

Special Rules for the Beginner Plan	
- The main goal of this process is long-term health and sustainability. No single day matters that much in the big scheme of growth, so cut yourself slack and have fun with it as much as possible! - The plan is not designed to be “Couch to 50k” or similar. Instead, an athlete would ideally be running at least 2-3 times per week (though the runs can be short) and generally active. If you’re coming off a longer layoff, consider 4-6 weeks of building up consistency with runs. If you haven’t run before, aim for 12 weeks of building consistency with running. - Ultra performance is all about 3 big principles for beginner athletes tackling the distance: hiking fast on uphill, running the downhills, and moving with purpose on the flats. The plan is designed to build long-term power while prioritizing those specific skills! - Most importantly, ultras often feel impossible when you start on the journey. Take it one mile at a time and WE GOT THIS.	

	Mon	Tues	Wed	Thurs	Fri	Sat	Sun
Week 1	Rest. Heat ideal like the sauna or hot tub, which improves blood volume	20-40 min easy run followed by fast hiking to reach 1 hour On the easy runs, just have fun and let yourself relax as much as you can. On the fast hiking after, pump your arms and really get moving You can mix in walk breaks during the run as well! When you do, keep the walk breaks fast like you'll be doing on race day. Walking is not a rest, it's just changing up movement patterns.	30-50 min easy run, followed by fast hiking to reach 75 minutes Same deal! At first, the entire goal is health and building up body for the impact You can add hiking time if you have time to spare! Speed Legs Strength Routine . Start this without any added weight, since it will probably make you super sore for 3-5 days if you haven't been doing these exercises.	X-train 40-60 minutes with 10 x 30 seconds fast/2 min easy. X-train can be bike, elliptical, or similar activities that don't cause impact. On the fast pushes, put it in a higher gear and work on power! You can go longer on these x-train days anytime if wanted, but I won't program that to avoid overwhelming people	20-40 min easy run followed by fast hiking to reach 1 hour	6 miles easy/moderate run/hike. On this adventure, the goal is to cover the distance purposefully. You can push a bit, hike really fast when it's time to hike, and try to practice running downhills quickly. Remember, downhills are free speed! Practice fueling and hydration like you'll be doing on race day on every long run You'll probably still be sore from Speed Legs, and that's ok.	2 hour hike or x-train You can mix activities on this day too. The goal is to go out with focus and move quick. Pump those arms when hiking and have fun with it! Speed Legs Strength Routine. You might need to wait until next week if sore still.
Week 2	Rest. Heat ideal	30-50 min easy run followed by fast hiking to	15 minutes easy run, 6 x 30 second hills fast with walk down	X-train 40-60 minutes with 10 x	20-40 min easy run	8 miles easy/moderate run/hike.	2 hour hike or x-train

Designed by David Roche & Megan Roche, MD PhD

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		reach 60-75 minutes.	recovery, 15 minutes easy run, plus hiking to reach 75-90 minutes total. On these hills, find a light grade around 4-6%, and push comfortably hard, with it getting harder as you go. The main goal is not to pull a muscle! Try to think "kid at recess," running with joy Speed Legs strength routine	30 seconds fast/90 seconds easy	followed by fast hiking to reach 1 hour	Choose a fun route on these, and now really start focusing on downhill as opportunities to push a bit	Speed Legs strength routine
Week 3	Rest. Heat ideal	30-50 min easy run followed by fast hiking to reach 60-75 min	15 minutes easy, 3 x 90 second hills fast with jog down recovery, 3 x 45 second hills fast with walk down recovery, 15 minutes easy Same goal with hills, just a bit more workload! Starting on this Wednesday, you could add a cross training double if you'd like, where you go for 30-45 minutes sometime after running. Speed Legs strength routine	X-train 40-60 minutes easy Ideally feel some quad fatigue on these, putting in some solid work even though you're not going hard	20-40 min easy run followed by fast hiking to reach 1 hour	10 miles easy/moderate run/hike On this long run, try to start letting your heart rate get up on climbs a bit. Every day is an opportunity to embrace that feeling more!	2 hour hike or x-train Speed legs strength routine
Week 4	Rest. heat ideal	30-50 min easy run followed by fast hiking to reach 60-75 min	15 minutes easy, 10 x 30 seconds fast/90 seconds easy, 15 minutes easy We're off of hills now, woohoo! On these 30 second intervals, think smooth. We don't want to be sprinting or anything! This will improve running economy at slower paces too. No Speed Legs, as we want to reduce stress this week!	X-train 40-60 min easy	20-40 min easy run followed by fast hiking to reach 1 hour	8 miles easy/moderate run/hike Emphasize fueling on this one so you recovery for Sunday!	6 miles easy/moderate run/hike I bet this one feels surprisingly good! Speed legs strength routine
Week 5	Rest. Heat ideal	40-60 min easy run followed by fast hiking to reach 75 minutes	40-60 min easy run followed by fast hiking to reach 75-90 min	X-train 40-60 min	20-40 min easy run followed by	10 miles easy/moderate run/hike	6 miles easy/moderate run/hike

			Aerobic off-loading week before increasing the long run! Speed legs strength routine		fast hiking to reach 1 hour	The big thing to focus on now is the following principle: make sure downhills are as steep or steeper than race day, faster than race day. That will prevent health issues during the race itself. Just Say No To Rhabdo!	No Speed legs after higher volume week!
Week 6	Rest. Heat ideal	40-60 min easy run followed by fast hiking to reach 75 min	15 min easy, 10 x 1 min fast/2 min easy, 15 min easy On these faster intervals, think smooth and relaxed! No Speed Legs with new stresses!	40-60 minutes uphill treadmill hiking or x-train. Now we're introducing the star of the show: treadmill hiking. Set it to a grade where you can hike faster than the cutoff pace for your race if possible, at least 3 mph. Pump those arms and get to work!	20-40 min easy run or x-train followed by fast hiking to reach 1 hour If you're hiking fast on Thursday, consider x-train on Fridays	14 miles easy/moderate This one is stepping up in a major way! Hike as much as you need to, and view it as an adventure. Fuel well like race day!	2 hour hike or x-train Speed Legs strength routine
Week 7	Rest. Heat ideal	40-60 min easy run followed by fast hiking to reach 75 min	15 min easy, 4 x 2 min hills fast with jog down recovery, 4 x 1 min hills fast with jog down recovery, 15 min easy Now we're getting SPICY!!! Embrace that space! Speed Legs strength routine	40-60 min uphill treadmill hiking or x-train	20-40 min easy run followed by fast hiking to reach 1 hour or x-train to off-load body	12 miles easy/moderate	8 miles easy/moderate. Bigger volume weekend!!! You'll be eating these up now Speed Legs Strength routine
Week 8	Rest. Heat ideal	40-60 min easy run followed by fast hiking to reach 75 min	15 min easy, 12 x 1 min fast/90 seconds easy, 15 min easy Honing that speed, and it should feel more natural now! No Speed Legs	40-60 min uphill treadmill hiking or x-train	X-train 40-60 min. Off-loading now to prepare for bigger weekends!	16 miles easy/moderate Now we're in crunch time with the 2 biggest long runs the next 2 weeks! Focus on those downhills--steeper and faster downhills are key for the race to be safe and	10 miles easy/moderate Speed Legs strength routine

						fun.	
Week 9	Rest. Heat ideal	40-60 min easy run followed by fast hiking to reach 75 min	15 min easy, 5 x 3 minute hills mod/hard with jog down recovery, 15 min easy 3 minute hills are really tough, but you got this!!! No more Speed Legs now, letting body adapt for race day!	40-60 min uphill treadmill hiking or x-train	X-train 40-60 min	20 miles easy/moderate adventure! This is a practice run for the race! Really emphasize fast hiking when you're hiking and using the downhills	2 hour hike or x-train Athletes who are feeling really good could do a run up to 10 miles, but the main goal is health now
Week 10	Rest. Heat ideal	40-60 min easy run followed by fast hiking to reach 75 min	15 min easy, 5k mod/hard on slight net downhill ideally, 15 min easy Let's mess around and run a 5k PR here, ideally on a net downhill of 100-300 feet to get a solid stimulus!	40-60 min uphill treadmill hiking or x-train	20-40 min easy run followed by fast hiking to reach 1 hour or x-train to off-load the body	14 miles easy/moderate	10 miles easy/moderate
Week 11	Rest. Heat ideal	40-60 min easy run followed by fast hiking to reach 75 min	1 hour moderate, just starting warmed up and running nice and smooth, letting yourself have fun with the fitness	40-60 min uphill treadmill hiking or x-train	20-40 min easy run followed by fast hiking to reach 1 hour or x-train	8 miles easy/moderate	6 miles easy/moderate
Week 12	Rest. Heat ideal	15 min easy, 4 x 30 second hills, 10 min moderate, 5 min easy Giving your body a race-week stimulus so you aren't flat on the start line!	20-30 minutes easy	Rest and recovery	15-20 minutes easy	RACE!!! Really focus on moving with purpose, not lingering at aid stations, hydrating well with calories if possible, and having as much fun as possible. You'll cherish these memories forever!	CELEBRATION AND PIZZA. Pizza is not a requirement, but it's strongly encouraged.

WE ARE SO PROUD OF YOU!!!!